Leeks, rather than onions, are used as the basis of this soup, which gives the soup a certain sweetness from the outset.

cannellini bean and carrot soup

SERVES 4-6 **PREP** 10 MINS **COOK** 1 HR **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS

3–4 leeks, finely sliced
1 tbsp olive oil
1½ tbsp butter
1 x 14oz (400g) can cannellini beans, drained and rinsed, then drained again
3 medium carrots, finely chopped
salt and freshly ground black pepper
1 tsp medium curry powder (optional)
3¼ cups cold water
extra virgin olive oil, to serve

1 Heat the oil and melt the butter in a large, deep pan over very low heat. Add the leeks and cook for at least 10 minutes, adding a tiny bit of water when the leeks start to stick to the bottom of the pan.

2 Add the cannellini beans and carrots, then turn up the heat and stir well with a wooden spoon to mix the vegetables and flavors together. Let it simmer for 5–6 minutes. Season the soup with salt and pepper, and stir in the curry powder, if using. Add the water and bring to a boil. Cover with a lid, and simmer for 45 minutes.

3 Transfer the mixture to a blender and process until smooth, then ladle into serving bowls. Encourage your guests to add a bit of olive oil and some freshly ground black pepper to their soup—it makes a wonderful finishing touch.